

The Peer Review Process

IB 514: Scientific Writing

The Peer Review Pipeline

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Editor's Perspective

Reviewer's Perspective

Author's Perspective

First steps Rejection Management

Revising & Resubmitting

Workflow Response Letter

Proofing Process

Peer Review History

What happens after you hit submit?

- 1. Submission** Manuscript enters the journal's editorial system; author receives an acknowledgement and manuscript ID.
- 2. Editorial Triage** Editor-in-Chief or handling editor assesses scope fit and minimum quality threshold. **Desk rejection** occurs often within days without external review.
- 3. Reviewer Invitation** Editor invites 2–4 reviewers; many (most) decline. This stage can take days to several weeks.
- 4. External Review** Reviewers evaluate the manuscript and return written reports, within 2–8 weeks (often longer in practice).
- 5. Editorial Decision** Editor synthesises reviews into one of four (or more) outcomes: **accept**, **minor revision**, **major revision**, or **reject** (with or without prejudice).
- 6. Revision & Resubmission** Authors revise and submit response letter.
- 7. Acceptance & Production** Manuscript enters copyediting, typesetting, and proofing before online publication.

Typical timeline: first decision in 3–5 months; full acceptance in 6–18 months across all revision rounds.

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What editors are looking at

- **Scope:** does the manuscript fit the journal's aims and readership?
- **Significance:** does it advance the field enough to justify publication?
- **Novelty:** is it sufficiently distinct from recent literature?
- **Presentation:** is the manuscript professionally prepared?

Why desk rejection happens

- Obvious scope mismatch
- Insufficient (perceived) methodological rigour on first read
- Incomplete submissions (missing figures, references, etc.)
- Manuscript prepared for a different journal (wrong format, wrong citation style)

What this means for you as an author

- Tailor your cover letter to the journal
- Polished submissions reduces editorial hesitation
- Desk rejection is typically not a judgement of your science — it is usually a targeting problem

The Reviewer's Perspective

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What reviewers evaluate

- Conceptual framing, novelty, significance of research question
- Appropriateness and rigour of methods
- Validity of results and statistical analyses
- Interpretation: do conclusions follow from the data?
- Presentation: clarity, figures, writing quality
- Completeness of citations and engagement with prior work

What reviewers shouldn't be required to do

- Editing your manuscript for you
- Reading a poorly organised paper charitably

Reviewers are busy volunteers

- Clear, well-structured manuscripts reduce reviewer burden and tend to produce more constructive feedback
- Reviewer fatigue is real: dense, difficult manuscripts are evaluated less generously

Tip: as you revise your writing, ask yourself — *am I making it easy for a tired expert to understand and trust this work?*

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Accept Rare on first submission. Minor corrections likely requested at proofing stage.

Minor Revision The manuscript is broadly acceptable; targeted changes required. Typical turnaround: 2–4 weeks.

Major Revision Substantial work required (new analyses, restructuring, additional experiments). Usually one more full review round. Typical turnaround: 4–12 weeks. *This is the most common outcome.*

Reject The manuscript will not be reconsidered at this journal.¹ May include encouragement to resubmit elsewhere.

¹Entirely new manuscript expected for "rejection without prejudice."

First steps

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First steps after receiving reviews

- 1 Read once for overall tone — then **step away**
- 2 Return the next day and read for content, not emotion
- 3 Identify which comments require new analysis, which require writing, and which require clarification only
- 4 Distribute your synthesis and discuss a plan with co-authors *before* revising

Rejection Management

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Rejection is normal — not exceptional

- Rates can exceed 70–90%; desk rejection of 50%+ at high-impact journals
- Most published papers were rejected at least once
- Rejection does not mean the work is unpublishable — it usually means the targeting was wrong

What to do immediately after rejection

- Read the decision letter and reviews carefully — even a rejection often contains actionable feedback
- Discuss with co-authors: is the feedback *scientific* (revise before resubmitting) or *editorial* (wrong journal)?
- Identify the next target journal *before* making any revisions

Appealing: appropriate if review contains clear and foundational factual error or demonstrable misreading of the work. Rarely successful, can take weeks or months, and delays resubmission elsewhere

Rule of thumb: Rejection sucks. Get over it and aim to submit a rejected manuscript elsewhere quickly (< 4–6 weeks). **Momentum matters!**

Revision & Resubmission Workflow

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Organise before you write

- Extract all editor and reviewer comments into a single numbered list
- Identify overlap and dependencies:
 - Overlap across reviewers' comments
 - Revisions requiring new analyses prior to writing
- Set a revision timeline (considering journal's request); request extension early if needed

Revise manuscript and draft response letter in parallel

- Draft response as each comment is addressed, not retrospectively
- Track changes in manuscript (or use L^AT_EX diff tool)
- Keep change-tracked version for editor

Verify

- Every response references a line number in the revision
- Every comment has a response (even just "*Implemented on line x.*")
- Changes haven't broken figure or table references

Responding to Reviewer Feedback

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The response document is as important as the revision

- Editors often read your response *before* re-reading the manuscript — make it clear and complete
- Address **every** comment, even if you disagree
- Use a structured format: quote the comment, state your response, indicate the change made and its location²

Handle disagreement professionally

- You may respectfully decline a reviewer request — but you must explain why clearly and with evidence
- Phrase pushback as: *"We respectfully disagree because... and instead propose..."*
- Never argue with tone; argue with data and logic
- If two reviewers contradict each other, flag it to the editor, use it to your advantage (if appropriate), and propose a resolution

²See provided L^AT_EX template.

The Proofing Process

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Proofing is a **correction stage**, not a revision stage.
Increasingly done through journal's online proofing system.

Read very carefully, especially...

- All author names, affiliations, and corresponding author details
- All equation, special character, and Greek symbol rendering
- Figures and tables in the correct order, at sufficient resolution, correctly captioned

Practical notes

- Proofing deadlines are typically 48–72 hours
- Read proof against manuscript line by line, not from memory
- Uncaught errors become permanent in published record; corrections require formal erratum

Remember to celebrate!

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What did you learn from reading the peer review history of published papers?

For discussion:

- What stood out in the reviewers' comments?
- What stood out in the editor's decision letters?
- What did the authors do well in their responses?
- What would you have done differently?